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Paul

The persecutor who met the risen Jesus and carried the gospel to the Gentiles.

Paul, first known as Saul, was a strict Pharisee who tried to destroy the church. On the road to Damascus, the risen Jesus stopped him in his tracks. From that day he gave his life to the message he had fought. He travelled thousands of miles, planting churches across what is now Turkey and Greece. He was beaten, stoned, jailed and shipwrecked. Thirteen of his letters are in the New Testament. More than anyone, Paul showed that Gentiles are saved by grace through faith, just as Jews are. Acts ends with him in Rome, still preaching.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Saul</i> , "asked for"; Roman <i>Paulus</i> , "small"
Family	Tribe of Benjamin; son of a Pharisee (Philippians 3:5; Acts 23:6)
Background	Born in Tarsus; Roman citizen; a tentmaker (Acts 18:3; 22:3, 28)
When	Converted c. AD 33–35; died c. AD 64–67 (tradition)
Key places	Tarsus; Jerusalem; Damascus; Antioch; Corinth; Ephesus; Rome
Key people	Barnabas; Silas; Timothy; Luke; Priscilla and Aquila; Peter
Main passages	Acts 7:58–8:3; 9; 13–28; Romans – Philemon
Letters	Thirteen bear his name; authorship of some is debated

"I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me."

Galatians 2:20, KJV

The life of Paul

Dates are approximate (AD), combining Acts and Galatians 1–2. His death in Rome is tradition, not Scripture; some think he was released and imprisoned again.

Before c. AD 30 <i>Tarsus and Jerusalem</i>	● A zealous Pharisee Born in Tarsus, Saul is brought up at the feet of Gamaliel, more zealous than others his age. <i>Acts 22:3; Galatians 1:14; Philippians 3:5–6</i>
c. AD 33–35 <i>Jerusalem</i>	● The persecutor He consents to Stephen's death, drags believers to prison, and seeks letters to arrest them in Damascus. <i>Acts 7:58–8:3; 9:1–2</i>
c. AD 33–35 <i>Road to Damascus</i>	● Meets the risen Jesus A light strikes him down. Blind three days, he is healed and baptized by Ananias. <i>Acts 9:3–19</i>
c. AD 35–46 <i>Arabia, Tarsus, Antioch</i>	● The quiet years He preaches in Damascus, goes into Arabia, and works in Syria and Cilicia until Barnabas brings him to Antioch. <i>Galatians 1:15–24; Acts 9:19–30; 11:25–30</i>
c. AD 46–48 <i>Cyprus and Galatia</i>	● First journey Sent out with Barnabas, he preaches in Cyprus and Galatia, and is stoned at Lystra. <i>Acts 13:1–14:28</i>
c. AD 49–57 <i>Europe and Asia</i>	● Council and later journeys After the Jerusalem council, he plants churches in Philippi, Thessalonica and Corinth, then spends about three years in Ephesus. <i>Acts 15:1–21:16; 20:31</i>
c. AD 57–62 <i>Caesarea and Rome</i>	● Prisoner for Christ Arrested in the temple, he appeals to Caesar, survives shipwreck, and preaches two years in Rome under guard. <i>Acts 21:17–28:31</i>

Key activities

The order follows Acts. Paul's letters fill in his own thoughts and struggles along the way.

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- I Persecuted the church.** He "made havock of the church," and later called himself the chief of sinners. *Acts 8:3; 1 Timothy 1:15*

 - 2 Met the risen Lord.** On the Damascus road he asked, "Who art thou, Lord?" and heard, "I am Jesus whom thou persecutest." *Acts 9:3-6*

 - 3 Preached at once.** "And straightway he preached Christ in the synagogues, that he is the Son of God." *Acts 9:20-22*

 - 4 Was sent by the Spirit.** At Antioch the Holy Ghost said, "Separate me Barnabas and Saul." *Acts 13:1-3*

 - 5 Turned to the Gentiles.** When some Jews rejected the message, he said, "Io, we turn to the Gentiles." *Acts 13:44-48*

 - 6 Defended grace.** He resisted forced circumcision of Gentiles and rebuked Peter to his face. *Acts 15:1-2; Galatians 2:11-16*

 - 7 Answered the call to Europe.** A vision of a man saying "Come over into Macedonia, and help us" led him to Philippi. *Acts 16:9-15*

 - 8 Sang in prison.** Beaten and chained at Philippi, he and Silas prayed and sang praises at midnight. The jailer and his house believed. *Acts 16:22-34*

 - 9 Reasoned in Athens.** He spoke on Mars' hill about an altar "TO THE UNKNOWN GOD" and proclaimed the risen Christ. *Acts 17:22-34*

 - 10 Built up churches.** He stayed eighteen months in Corinth and about three years in Ephesus, teaching daily and working with his hands. *Acts 18:1-11; 19:8-10; 20:31-35*

 - 11 Wrote letters.** He wrote to churches and co-workers to teach, correct and encourage them. *Romans 1:1-7; 2 Thessalonians 3:17*

 - 12 Testified before rulers.** He spoke before Felix, Festus and King Agrippa, and he said, "I appeal unto Caesar." *Acts 24-26; 25:11*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Paul.

Old Testament

Habakkuk 2:4; Genesis 15:6	Roots of his teaching on faith (Romans 1:17; 4:3)
Isaiah 49:6	"A light of the Gentiles," taken as his calling (Acts 13:47)
Echo: Jeremiah 1:5	Set apart before birth (Galatians 1:15)

New Testament

Acts 7:58–28:31	The main account, from Stephen's death to Rome
Acts 9; 22:3–21; 26:9–23	His conversion told three times
Romans – Philemon	Thirteen letters bearing his name
2 Corinthians 11:23–28	His beatings, shipwrecks and dangers
2 Timothy 4:6–8	"I have fought a good fight"
2 Peter 3:15–16	Peter's "beloved brother Paul"
Tradition	Beheaded in Rome under Nero; his writing Hebrews is debated

For discussion

- Observe:* What did Jesus say to Saul on the Damascus road, and how did Saul respond (Acts 9:3–9)?
- Understand:* Why do you think Paul kept calling himself the chief of sinners (1 Timothy 1:15–16)?
- Apply:* Who have you quietly given up on, and how can you pray for them this week?
- Apply:* Who could you encourage this week with a note, a message or a visit?